3.0. THEORIES OF GENDER ROLE DEVELOPMENT

3.1. Introduction

Human differentiation on the basis of gender is a fundamental phenomenon that affects virtually every aspect of people's daily lives. Theories of gender role development and functioning specifies how gender conceptions are constructed from the complex mix of experiences and how they operate in concert with motivational and self-regulatory mechanisms to guide gender-linked conduct throughout the life course. These theories integrate psychological and socio-structural determinants within a unified conceptual structure.

In these theoretical perspectives, gender conceptions and roles are the product of a broad network of social influences operating interdependently in a variety of social settings. It is obvious that human evolution provides bodily structures and biological potentialities that permit a range of possibilities rather than dictating a fixed type of gender differentiation. People contribute to their self-development and bring about social changes that define and structure gender relationships through their actions within the interrelated systems of influence.

3.2. Social Learning/Cognitive Theory

According to Bandura (1977), Social Learning Theory is based on the idea that we learn from our interactions with others in a social context.

Hence, by observing the behaviors of others, people develop similar behaviors. According to this theory, also called Social Cognitive Theory, an individual's behavior is shaped by the reaction of others and more so when it is rewarded or punished.

Hence personality is shaped through learning as people observe and process information about their social environment in order to maximize favorable outcomes from others (see Bem, 1981; 1983; Weiten & Lloyd, 1997).

The punishments or rewards act as deterrents and reinforcements respectively and since reactions to behavior are specific to sexes; people tend to develop masculine and feminine behavior including involvement in certain livelihood and development activities. As such, behaviors that are ignored by the society are likely to fade away while those reinforced for example through rewards are likely to be repeated in anticipation of additional rewards.

The main way that gender behaviors are learned is through the process of observation through which children observe the people around them behaving in various ways, some of which relate to gender. They pay attention to some of these people (models) and encode their behavior. At a later stage they may imitate the behavior they have observed, but more emphasis is given to enacting behavior that is likely to get societal approval. The child is more likely to attend to and imitate those people it perceives as similar to itself (Bandura, 1977; Santrock, 2007). Consequently, it is more likely to imitate behavior modeled by same-sexed people. In addition, people around the child are likely to respond to the child's imitated behavior with either reinforcement or punishment.

The foregoing reinforcement is more certain when they act in gender-specific ways and punished or ignored for contrary behavior (Beal, 1994; Santrock, 2007). Moreover, the child is also expected to have observed the consequences of other people's behavior and will be motivated to imitate the behavior which has been reinforced and avoid imitating the behavior that was punished. For people to learn, Santrock (2007) and Beal (1994) concur that two concepts are important**: role models and their representativeness**. As far as role models are concerned, people copy the behavior of those they admire for example parents and significant others. For this reason, the absence or presence of role models of a certain gender is significant for the development of gender-specific behavior (Beal, 1994). In addition, the development of such behavior is also aided by the general society through its various social reactions (rewards or punishments) to the particular individual.

As far as representativeness is concerned, Beal (1994) has pointed out that people want to copy the behavior of others who they think are appropriate or usual as opposed to those who are unusual. Hence, boys tend to imitate masculine behavior while girls are more likely to emulate feminine behavior as long as each is sure what they are imitating is socially acceptable and typical of their gender. Flowing from the foregoing, it can be inferred that different treatment of boys and girls by the society, largely shapes their respective behavior, ambition and the future activities including career choices. As such, they learn behavior by observing and imitating same-sexed role models (see Bem, 1983; Ickes, 1993).

However, Brain (2000) cautions that although individuals learn through observation and imitation, not any behavior is imitated and internalized. Hence people model and imitate behavior that they believe will maximize rewards and minimize punishment, pro-social behavior. For this reason, reinforcement such as approval by the society is important for modeling and imitation of behavior as it determines whether certain behavior is copied or not. Hence for behavior to be copied, the model must be attractive to the observer and at the same time the consequences of his/her behavior must get societal approval. It is instructive to point out that reinforcement is motivational since one is more likely to repeat the same behavior if the consequences are favorable to him and especially when they get society approval.

As far as the development of gender roles are concerned, children learn what is *appropriate* for each gender first from parents and significant others within the family and subsequently as they interact with other social institutions in their social milieu (see Santrock, 2007). In their growth and development, children observe, imitate and eventually internalize the specific attitudes and behaviors that their culture defines as gender appropriate by using other males and females as roles models (see Ickes, 1993; Juni, Rahamin & Brannon, 2001; Lynch, 2007). The bottom-line is that gender socialization implies that boys and girls are treated differently and put into different learning

environments. As a result, they develop different skills, needs, desires, wants and temperaments-they become different people, men and women throughout generations so that their differences become largely accepted and regarded as natural (see Lynch, 2007).

Hence, sex-role development is seen by this theory as deriving from an internalization of characteristics of same-sexed parent, reinforced by an effort to contrast oneself from the opposite sexed-parent and the attendant roles in Freudian hypothesis (Bem, 1981; 1983; Juni, Rahamin & Brannon, 2001; Santrock, 2007). From the foregoing and as far as this theory is concerned, it can be inferred that the roles women and men take respectively in development are partly a consequence of gender role socialization early in life. The theory will therefore be useful in explaining why men take different roles from women as far as development activities are concerned. However, it needs to be pointed out that gender roles are culture and community-specific and dynamic on a time-space distinction. For this reason, some deviation from the culturally-sanctioned social organization of the resident communities including gender-based division of labor is not unexpected.

3.3. Gender Schema Theory

Schema (the patterns of thought). Gender schema theory refers to the hypothesis that people learn about what it means to be male or female from the culture in which they live and accordingly adjust their behavior to fit within its gender norms and expectations (Bem, 1983). Gender schemas have an impact not only on how people process information but on the attitudes and beliefs that direct "gender-appropriate" behavior. It therefore concerns the development of an **internal mental framework**, which organizes and directs the behavior of an individual as a male or female. For example, the gender schema of being male might include believing that one can play football and actually engages in it. Another ex. a child who lives in a very traditional culture might believe that a woman's role is in the caring and raising of children, while a man's role is in work and industry. Through these observations, children form schema related to what men and women can

and cannot do.This means, an **individual's attitude and behavior are guided by an internal motivation** to conform to gender-based socio-cultural standards and stereotypes (Bem, 1981; 1983). Hence, just like in the case of Social Learning Theory, observation, imitation, rewards and punishment are the main drivers of the development of gender-specific behavior (see Santrock, 2007).

However, unlike the Social Learning Theory in which individuals are largely motivated by the rewards of others as a result of the behavior they exhibit, in the gender schema theory, the emphasis is **on internal as opposed to external motivation**. While interaction with the social environment is important for sex-role development, in this theory, individuals construct their own gender world, with minimal external influence. Gender schema theory hence (see Bem 1981) focuses on the role of individual cognitive organization in addition to environmental socialization. This theory postulates that children learn how their cultures and/or societies define the roles of men and women and then internalize this knowledge as a gender schema, or unchallenged core belief. Children's perceptions of men and women are thus an interaction between their gender schemas and their experiences (see Beal, 1994). Eventually, children will incorporate their own self-concepts into their gender schema and will assume the traits and behaviors that they deem suitable for their gender.

It is through the schemas that children see and construct their world leading to the development of gender-specific attitudes, expectations, skills and beliefs. These are internalized, become institutionalized in their behavior and thus the development of gender-based roles can be explained. In adult life, people adopt behaviors that are gender-specific as a result of the mental schemas that were learned and internalized early in life. The Gender Schema Theory can hence be used to explain why men take some tasks as women take different ones in society. For example, it can be used to explain why there are many men mechanics, security forces, drivers, masons and carpenters or why women are overrepresented in trades like dressmaking, hairdressing, nursing, teaching, etc.

3.4. Role Theory

Role theory is based on the study of a role, a cluster of social cues/signs that guide and determine an individual's behavior in a certain setting. Role theory is one of the theories of socialization, which unlike the others focuses on **role enactment**. It is associated with W. Archer (1889) as expounded by Lindsey and Aronson (1968) and Santrock (2007), who opine/lecture that an individual's overt/obvious conduct in a particular setting forms the initial specifications of role enactment. For any role one has to play as a result of being in a certain position, there is a role expectation, the central concept in role theory. Role expectation comprise of rights and privileges, duties and obligations of any occupant of a social position, in relation to others occupying other positions in the social system. The occupant of a certain position is thus expected to exhibit behavior which goes along with the position and which should be in line with the socially sanctioned/authorized norms and values. The structure of role expectation in a social system is organized so that meaningful behavioral unity emerges to create order.

The foregoing/preceding implies that roles in a social system are complimentary and role expectations facilitate social interaction by providing those who interact with means of reciprocal prediction of behavior. An occupant of a position ought hence, to behave in a way expected of his/her position by the normative group of which he/she is a member (see Mwenzwa, 2011a; Santrock, 2007). For example, in society, women are culturally expected to be submissive to men, while men on the other hand are expected to be outgoing. Role expectations hence define the limits of tolerated behavior which need not be overstepped due to attendant sanctions including the withdrawal of privileges and respect that go with conformity (Santrock, 2007). Hence, role expectation which is acquired during the process of socialization induces conformity in the individual as far as societal norms are concerned.

Role theory hence can be seen as the approach to social structure that locates its basic constraints in **stereotyped** interpersonal expectations. Thus, the basic idea is that being a man or a woman means enacting a general role definitive of one's sex, the sex role. This

means that the process of socialization into sex-specific roles produce feminine or masculine characteristics and behavior and their attendant institutionalization. The institutionalization is made possible by the presence of social institutions like the family which promotes its values in the individual (see Lynch, 2007).

Socialization imposes sex-specific roles and constraints that shape self-images, attitudes and ambitions. Girls are expected to be passive and obedient while boys should be active, outgoing and competitive in preparation for the future private and public spheres respectively (see Hooks, 1984; Santrock, 2007). Indeed, role expectations are comprised of the privileges, duties and obligations of any occupant of a social position and the role player's behavior is dependent on the behavior of those occupying complimentary positions (see Solomon et al, 1985; Beal, 1994). In this case, gender-role socialization should be seen as an important driver that defines division of labor in society including that based on gender. This perspective is therefore useful in determining the specific roles that men and women play in development activities resulting from gender-role socialization.

3.5. Summary

When explaining how gender identity and roles develop, psychologists emphasize the role of **thinking processes**. They are interested in how children gather and make sense of information about gender and how their understanding of gender changes over time (a **developmental** perspective). Cognitive psychologists assume that changes in gender role behavior reflect changes in how children understand and think about gender. These in turn, reflect the accumulation of **information** about gender gathered from the environment and developmental changes in the child's **brain** that allows it to process information in more sophisticated ways.